some point it decided to swing west towards the Indus. The old channels flowing east remain visible in satellite photographs.

The same process may even have cost the Saraswati its own perennial source of glacial water. A Rig Vedic hymn hints that it may have had three separate sources. [19] There is some research that argues that the Tons river, that is today a major tributary of the Yamuna, may have been one of the original sources of glacial water for the Saraswati, and that it flowed into the plains through the channel of the Markanda, which is yet another of the Ghaggar's tributaries. [20]

Without a perennial water source, the Saraswati must have become a rain-fed seasonal river. Even this became untenable as the climate became drier. Eventually, the river broke up into a series of lakes and then completely dried up. The dry riverbed of the Ghaggar is all that is now left although it does occasionally flow after an especially heavy monsoon season.

Nevertheless, the river was not forgotten. We find its memory echoed in legends, folk tales and place-names. Modern Hindus still worship the Saraswati as the Goddess of Knowledge, recalling the river's role as an 'inspirer of hymns'. In Haryana, one of the seasonal tributaries of the Ghaggar is called the Sarsuti. Farther south, a seasonal river called Saraswati rises in the Aravallis and flows into the Rann of Kutchh, not far from the estuary of the lost river. Deep in the deserts of Rajasthan, the Pushkar lake recalls many legends about the Goddess Saraswati. Where the Yamuna joins the Ganga at Allahabad, there is a legend that the Saraswati flows underground. Perhaps it is a way to remember the fact that the Yamuna was once a tributary of the lost river.

The shifting of the rivers may explain one of the mysteries of the subcontinent's wildlife: how the Gangetic and Indus river dolphins came to belong to the same species. Till the 1990s they were considered separate species but now they are classified as sub-species Platanista Gangetica Gangetica and Platanista Gangetica Minor. The problem is that the two river systems are today not connected, and the dolphins obviously could not